maybe, that I can't spend a few hours playing in the sea with my family while I'm there. Anyway, it was great to have some time to relax and just be with each other while, I imagined, life rolled on back at home.

I came back fresh and couldn't wait to be playing again, although I was still a couple of weeks short of being ready for a game. Something had changed, though, while I'd been away. Almost as soon as I started work on building up my fitness at Carrington, I began to feel a chill in the atmosphere: not around the club, but between me and Alex Ferguson. It's often like that when you're injured. You're not involved and so it's as if you don't really exist. Obviously, the manager has to get on with winning matches with the players he's got.

This felt like something different, though. Perhaps if I'd known what was going to happen over the next few weeks, I'd have been able to do something about it before events spun out of control. After the ten happiest years of my life at Old Trafford, how could I ever have imagined that things were going to unravel, and so quickly, to a point where I'd find myself wondering whether my future didn't lie away from United, or even away from soccer altogether?

The boss hardly said a word to me at training or anywhere else. After a month of getting the cold shoulder, I decided I needed to find out what was going on. In the past, any kind of meeting with the boss would have been intimidating just to think about. I'd be standing in front of him and, before I'd said a word, my bottom lip would be starting to go. I've always been stubborn but I'm older now and more mature as a person. Most important of all, I'm surer of myself. I've got my wife believing in me to thank for that. I asked the manager if I could see him and said it straight out:

'Is there a problem? Have you got a problem with me?'

He did. A big problem. To be specific, it was that, instead of going straight off on vacation, I'd gone to Buckingham Palace with the rest of the England players. He reckoned I'd have been fit sooner if I hadn't waited those extra couple of days before going away. I tried to argue my case. As I understood it from the doctors, there's nothing you can do that will hurry a recovery from a broken rib: it's four weeks' rest and that's that. As for going to Buckingham Palace, I tried to explain:

'I'm England captain. Never mind that I was proud to be asked to go and meet the Queen, I'd have been ripped apart in the papers if I hadn't been there. The whole World Cup squad was there. I felt it was my duty to be there too. Ashley Cole got abuse because he turned up wearing sneakers. What